minister of India, never. However, if he wants, we could arrange a tea stall for him here.'

When I interviewed Mani that night, he refused to accept the charge that he had called Modi a 'chaiwallah'. 'You have a bad habit of distorting everything I say, Rajdeep. You and your channel are past masters at this,' and then almost ripped off his mike.

Mani's political journey had been full of ups and downs. A former IFS officer and a senior of Rajiv Gandhi at Doon and Cambridge, he had joined politics in the 1980s, enamoured by Rajiv's fresh-faced zest to build a new kind of politics. The dream had died a long time ago, but Mani remained a family loyalist, a self-described Nehruvian 'secular fundamentalist'. Labelled a sycophant by his critics, he had seen his own political career drift into near oblivion. He had made panchayati raj his calling card, but this was never going to be enough to sustain his politics, especially as he was from Tamil Nadu, a state where the Congress was a marginal player. He had been removed as petroleum minister, allegedly because he wouldn't bend before the Ambanis; as sports minister, because he detested the Commonwealth Games chief Suresh Kalmadi. He was now a Rajya Sabha backbencher, a nominated MP, courtesy Sonia Gandhi.

His pungent humour made him an entertainer on television; his acerbic tongue meant he had few friends left in politics. At times, it seemed he had never grown out of a debating fraternity in Doon School and St Stephens College, a still too-clever-by-half septuagenarian brat. But this was not a school or college debate where you could throw punches and then share a few laughs. This was a real-life political *akhara*, the jousting being played out on live television. You can be critical of an opponent in politics, but being disrespectful and socially contemptuous is fraught with danger.

I had seen both sides of Mani. He could be a wonderfully convivial host, generous with his food, drink and intellect. But he could also get vicious and personal in debates on TV. 'I don't ever want to come on your channel again—you have no clue what you are saying,' he spat at me once during a nightly slugfest. Next morning, in Parliament, he was happily inviting me for a Track 2 dialogue with Pakistan, another pet subject of his.